Farewell Address — ‘Military-Industrial Complex’

President Dwight D. Eisenhower · January 17, 1961

Source: Dwight D. Eisenhower, Farewell Address (Jan. 17, 1961), text via the Avalon Project, Yale Law School. Public domain.

Three days before John F. Kennedy’s inauguration, the outgoing Eisenhower addressed the nation. A former five-star general, Eisenhower had presided over the largest peacetime military buildup in American history — and in this address warned that the permanent national-security state itself had become a danger to democratic government. The phrase ‘military-industrial complex’ became one of the most enduring coinages of any 20th-century presidential speech.

> *Connect: Eisenhower — a former general — warned about the military establishment’s power. Washington in his Farewell (Class 7) warned about permanent alliances and standing armies. What’s the American tradition of civilian suspicion of the military?*

Key Passages

On size and scope

> Until the latest of our world conflicts, the United States had no armaments industry. American makers of plowshares could, with time and as required, make swords as well. But now we can no longer risk emergency improvisation of national defense; we have been compelled to create a permanent armaments industry of vast proportions. Added to this, three and a half million men and women are directly engaged in the defense establishment. We annually spend on military security more than the net income of all United States corporations.

The phrase

> In the councils of government, we must guard against the acquisition of unwarranted influence, whether sought or unsought, by the military-industrial complex. The potential for the disastrous rise of misplaced power exists and will persist. We must never let the weight of this combination endanger our liberties or democratic processes. … Only an alert and knowledgeable citizenry can compel the proper meshing of the huge industrial and military machinery of defense with our peaceful methods and goals, so that security and liberty may prosper together.

On the scientific establishment

> Today, the solitary inventor, tinkering in his shop, has been overshadowed by task forces of scientists in laboratories and testing fields. In the same fashion, the free university, historically the fountainhead of free ideas and scientific discovery, has experienced a revolution in the conduct of research. Partly because of the huge costs involved, a government contract becomes virtually a substitute for intellectual curiosity.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Cold War arms race and the permanent defense industry that grew from World War II and Korea, as Eisenhower handed power to John F. Kennedy.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The American public, through a televised national address.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Dwight Eisenhower, the outgoing president and former five-star general, who understood the military establishment and feared its growing power.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. LEQ Thesis (1 pt): Write a defensible thesis on the costs and benefits of the postwar national-security state.
2. Identify TWO specific Cold War programs Eisenhower had a hand in expanding.
3. Compare this speech with Washington's Farewell Address. What anxieties carried across 165 years?